

ALAMY

SPORTS

IN A LEAGUE OF ITS OWN

*The **Indian Super League (ISL)** is back for an 11th edition—and an exciting season is expected*

A decade is a long wait. Ask NorthEast United FC. The best result for the football club, which has been a part of the Indian Super League (ISL) since the inaugural season in 2013–14, came in 2021 when they finished third on the league table and were eliminated in the semi-final of the playoff. All that changed in September this year when they clinched their first silverware after beating Mohun Bagan Super Giant on penalties to lift the Durand Cup. And just like that, they threw themselves in contention for the coveted ISL trophy when the 11th season got underway on September 13.

"After the final, I congratulated the players and told them that they deserved a pat on the back. But that's about it, we woke



LET'S PLAY BALL Captains of teams in ISL 2024-25 pose with the trophy in Kolkata, Sept. 4

Enduring freezing conditions, **NEHA TIKAM** clocked 44 hours 27 minutes and dedicated her effort to the Border Roads Organisation



By the time Neha Tikam started the climb to Tanglang La, the highest point (5,328m) on the Manali-Leh highway, she knew things were going to get tricky on the rest of her ride. The rain lower down in Rumtse had made way for sleet and the temperature had dropped significantly as she pedalled uphill in the rarefied environment of Ladakh.

Her aim was to set the fastest time by a female cyclist on the Manali-Leh stretch, a distance of 430 km with a total elevation gain of around 5,800 metres. When she rode past the finish point at 3.27 am on August 17, Tikam had endured extreme weather conditions and a landslide near Manali that had made the going rough. But she still managed to get the record after clocking 44 hours 27 minutes, dedicating her effort to the Border Roads Organisation.

"During a race on the same route in 2019, I had fallen ill and had taken close to three days to finish. I knew I wanted to come back and targeting a record seemed like the right way to do it," Tikam, 42, says. Since the start of the year, Pune-based Tikam took on multiple brevets (a